

Sources

Provided: <https://thehill.com/blogs/in-the-know/in-the-know/314282-katy-perry-produced-psa-asks-if-wwii-history-is-repeating/>

<https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2024/apr/04/mexico-border-children-migrant-camps-explained>

<https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2023/nov/27/us-mexico-border-asylum-open-air-detention-center-california>

HW:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hl4NoVWq87M>

Classwork:

12a | WW2 Japanese Incarceration

Hist 15 | 2a WW2 Incarceration | Workshop Group 1

Outline

Introduction:

- Introduction of topic: U.S. government's history of detaining marginalized groups (national security or border enforcement)
- Name both periods: WWII Japanese American incarceration (1942-1945) and modern U.S.-Mexico border migrant detention camps (2023-present)
- Thesis: Although separated by over 80 years, both periods reveal a destructive pattern – fear-driven policies, dehumanizing camps, and the erosion of human rights for people deemed to be different or “harmful” by the government
- Preview the 3 sections: historical period, modern period, comparison, and meaning

Historical Period: Japanese American Incarceration (1942-1945)

- Context: After Pearl Harbor, fear and racism rose, leading the U.S. government to target Japanese Americans as threats despite no evidence of disloyalty to America.
- Executive Order 9066 gave the military authority to remove people from their homes without naming any ethnic group directly
- **Paraphrased from handout (Cat A): Source: "U.S. President Orders Incarceration: Feb 1942 | Executive Order 9066" — 12a WW2 Japanese Incarceration: On Feb. 19, 1942, President Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066, granting military commanders the power to forcibly remove people from designated military areas (applied to 120,000 Japanese Americans, with 2/3 of them being U.S.-born citizens.**
- Living conditions inside the camps were overcrowded, unsanitary, and not prepared for the harsh conditions (put together too quickly)
- **(Cat B): Source: "Ugly History: Japanese American Incarceration Camps" — Densho / TED-Ed (YouTube transcript): “Guarded by army soldiers, many of these camps were still being constructed when incarcerated moved in. These hastily built prisons were overcrowded and unsanitary. People frequently fell ill and were unable to receive proper medical care.”**
- **(Cat A): Paraphrased: Source: "Gordon Hirabayashi Interview | Seattle, Washington, May 25, 1999" — Hist 15 | 12a WW2 | Incarceration | Workshop Group 1: An interview in 1999, Gordon Hirabayashi recalled how he concluded that obeying the curfew and removal orders was a betrayal of his own values, so he turned to resistance and to advocate for the democratic principles that country claims to stand for.**
- Survivor testimony reinforces the human cost: real families labeled strictly on race and stripped of human rights.
- **(Cat C): Source: "Is History Repeating Itself?" PSA — produced by Katy Perry (YouTube transcript): “My entire family was put on a registry. We were given name tags and numbers, and then we had to wear them. Then we were put on a train, and I had no idea where I was going... We had to leave out businesses, our homes, and our possessions behind...”**

The Modern Period: U.S.-Mexico border migrant detention (2023-present)

- Context: Political pressure, as well as overwhelmed processing centers, have too many migrants, including children, in open-air camps with minimal resources.
- The government claimed migrants were not “in detention.”
- **(Cat C): Source: "Is History Repeating Itself?" PSA — produced by Katy Perry (YouTube transcript): “If you issued somebody a bracelet, and given them the parameters of where to be, and aren’t giving them various instructions starting from the time they cross, and they know that they have cooperate with border patrol to be compliant with the asylum process that they have a legal right to, then how is that not being detained?”**
- Conditions are dangerous – freezing nights, low food, low medical care, no sanitation
- **(Cat 3): Source: Velasco, Paulina. "Detained in the desert." The Guardian, Nov. 27, 2023. ("Aunt Bunny," volunteer medic): “One bottle of water a day and one granola bar – that’s what CBP is giving the people – doesn’t have a high enough caloric intake...”**
- Children are most vulnerable (unaccompanied) without food, medical care, shelter, etc.
- **(Cat C): Source: Singh, Maanvi. "What are the US-Mexico border camps and why are children held there?" The Guardian, Apr. 4, 2024.: “Advocates have been raising the alarm for months that migrants, including unaccompanied children, are suffering from hunger, dehydration, untreated injuries, and illness in outdoor holding areas on the California-Mexico border...”**
- A federal judge ruled that children were in legal custody and were entitled to rights, the same slow correction seen in WWII
- **(Cat C): Source: Singh, Maanvi. "What are the US-Mexico border camps..." The Guardian, Apr. 4, 2024. (Judge Dolly M. Gee ruling): “Juveniles, unlike adults, are always in some form of custody.”**

Comparison Contrast: 3 Cs

- Similarity: The U.S. government used language that minimized the situation– “relocation centers” (1942), denying the centers as detention(2023)
- Difference: WWII targeted U.S. citizens who were a “threat” and “helping” the Japanese. The modern period detains people who came voluntarily to request legal protection.
- Both groups are denied basic human rights and conditions
- Context: Both situations were intentional and resulted from government decisions made under pressure, while still overriding constitutional and humanitarian rights and obligations
- Both cases: non-government organizations filled the gap left by the states

Conclusion

- Most striking: Governments' consistent use of generic and “work-around” language to get their way and abuse the wording of the constitution.
- The fact that legal correction came in both cases suggests the system can self-correct (2024 court ruling for migrant children) but it takes lots of time.

- Connection to historical thinking: These incidents are parallels that display the repeating patterns of the governmental and racial ideals
- Personal angle: I am aware that this affected SJSU students during the WWII period and that JACL was founded here. The history is always local.

Essay

Japanese Internment Camps in Relation to Modern Immigrant Internment Camps

In the United States, the line between national security and racial victimization has been crossed in the past. During WWII, the federal government detained over 120,000 Japanese people – most of them being U.S. citizens – in incarceration camps under the justification of the war. Today, along the U.S.-Mexico border, adults and unaccompanied children are being held in open-air camps without adequate food, shelter, or medical care. Officials deny that they are being detained at all. Although the two periods are more than eighty years apart and involve very different groups of people, the patterns are familiar: fear-driven policies, dehumanizing conditions, and a slow, unaccepting government that is failing to care for its people in custody. Examining these two periods reveals not only the patterns but also why learning about our history still matters today in the present.

The historical period began with the attack on Pearl Harbor in February 1942. Two months later, President Franklin D. Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066, granting military commanders the power to forcibly remove people from designated military areas – a broad term that allowed the removal of almost the entire Japanese American population, stripping over 120,000 people of their homes, businesses, and constitutional rights.¹ What followed was not a “relocation” program, but a mass incarceration of Japanese Americans into rapidly constructed, unfinished prisons. As the TED-Ed video *Ugly History: Japanese American Incarceration Camps explains*, “Guarded by armed soldiers, many of these camps were still being constructed when incarcerated people moved in. These hastily built prisons were overcrowded and unsanitary. People frequently fell ill and were unable to receive proper medical care.”² Families were packed into horse stables, stripped of their privacy, and surrounded by barbed wire – all under the governmental claim of being put in “relocation centers.”

Not everyone accepted this. Gordon Hirabayashi, a University of Washington student, refused to comply. In this oral interview in Seattle – assigned to Workshop Group 1 – Hirabayashi spoke about his recall to understanding that obeying the curfew and removal orders meant betraying his own values. Therefore, he turned himself in to the FBI as an act of resistance, insisting that the targeting of Japanese Americans was purely dependent on race and violated the constitutional principles that the country claims to be based on.³ His case went to the Supreme Court and was lost in 1943, until it was overturned in 1987. His resistance is a reminder of the constitutional violation that was visible to the victims; it was not only obvious in hindsight.

The human cost of these policies is found in the testimonies of the incident’s survivors. In the public service announcement *Is History Repeating Itself?*, by Katy Perry, a survivor named Haru Kia describes what happened to her family: “My entire family was put on a registry. We had been given name tags and numbers, and then we had to wear them...We had to leave out businesses, our homes, and our possessions behind – even our pets.”⁴ This proves that real

¹ “U.S. President Orders Incarceration: Feb 1942 | Executive Order 9066,” from 12a | WW2 Japanese Incarceration, HIST 15

² “Ugly History: Japanese American Incarceration Camps,” Densho / TED-Ed

³ Gordon Hirabayashi Interview,” Seattle, Washington, May 25, 1999, from HIST 15 | 12a WW2 | Incarceration | Workshop Group 1

⁴ *Is History Repeating Itself?*, public service announcement produced by Katy Perry,

families, labeled and processed like inventory, had lost everything – not because they did anything wrong, but because of who they were.

The modern period offers a different group of victims but a similar scenario. Beginning in late 2023, U.S. Customs and Border Protection began to relocate unaccompanied children and adults to wait in open-air detention camps in the California desert near San Diego. Border Patrol insists that these migrants are not being held in custody, although the conditions tell a different story. Paulina Velasco's article "Detained in the desert: migrants stuck in camps in the extreme climate of the U.S.-Mexico border," published in December 1, 2023, tells a story about Jacqueline Arellano, director of U.S. programs for Border Kindness, pushed back on this claim: "If you issued somebody a bracelet, and given them the parameters of where to be, and aren't giving them various instructions starting from the time they cross, and they know that they have to cooperate with border patrol to be compliant with the asylum process that they have a legal right to, then how is that not being detained?"⁵ The wristbands, restricted movement, and dependency on Border Patrol all connect to the true story of the detention camps, regardless of the federal label.

These conditions inside the camps are anything but pleasant. In the same *Guardian* report by Velasco, a volunteer medic known as "Aunt Bunny" described the situation: "One bottle of water a day and one granola bar – that's what CBP is giving the people – doesn't have a high enough caloric intake... The Trauma wounds from the Darién become infected and start bursting. It's a mess. It's a mess."⁶ Volunteers, rather than the government, have been keeping the people in these camps alive through providing water, food, insulin, and tending to wounds from crossing the Darién Gap. Children suffer the most in these camps due to their developing immune systems and need for nutrition during growth. According to Maanvi Singh from *The Guardian's* "What are the U.S.-Mexico border camps and why are children held there?", "Advocates have been raising the alarm for months that migrants, including unaccompanied children, are suffering from hunger, dehydration, untreated injuries, and illness in outdoor holding areas on the California-Mexico border that lack shelter, food, and sanitation."⁷ In the same article, Singh reports that the federal government and court ruled that these children were in legal custody and entitled to protection. This was written as follows: "Juveniles, unlike adults, are always in some form of custody."⁸ This ruled that the obvious policies that volunteers had been advocating for months had to be followed by the government.

The parallels between the two periods are alarming in how close the event timelines align. In both cases, the government used general language to hide what was actually happening – "relocation centers" in 1942, "not in detention" in 2023. In both cases, conditions were dangerous and unsanitary, camps were rapidly built, and the incarcerated depended on

⁵ Paulina Velasco, "Detained in the desert: migrants stuck in camps in the extreme climate of the US-Mexico border," *The Guardian*, December 1, 2023.

⁶ Velasco, "Detained in the desert."

⁷ Maanvi Singh, "What are the US-Mexico border camps and why are children held there?" *The Guardian*, April 4, 2024.

⁸ Singh, "What are the US-Mexico border camps." Constitution

outside volunteers to fill the safety gaps left by the state. In both cases, the law eventually caught up: The 1988 Civil Liberties Act that apologized for the WWII incarceration, and Judge Gee's 2023 ruling that forced the government to recognize children's legal and safety status. The difference between the events was simply who was being detained. In 1942, the targets were U.S. citizens who came from Japanese ancestry who were forcibly removed from their homes. In 2023, most of the people held were asylum seekers who came voluntarily to request legal protection. However, in both cases, the government denied them basic human rights and dignity that the Constitution is supposed to require. The context driving each situation comes from a common cause. Post-Pearl Harbor hysteria led to Executive Order 9066. Today, the mass media surrounding border patrol, immigration, and the overwhelmed processing system have led to the implementation and collapse of open-air camps. Neither situation is accidental. Both eras have had officials who chose convenience over constitutional rights, even when real harm is being done.

What I find most interesting about this connection is how consistently the government uses generalized language to hide the true consequences of its actions. This can also be seen today with the "conflict" in Iran, where the general public does not know where their \$1 billion a day of tax dollars is going, nor the true war that is unfolding overseas. Studying these parallels is more than an academic exercise. This is a training in recognizing historical patterns – the language use, the conditions, the governmental justifications – before they unfold. That is the real value of learning history, and it is why a true U.S. history class matters beyond the grade.